

Seepage Wetland

PHOTO BY ERIN CORK, GA DNR

IMPORTANCE TO FORESTRY OPERATIONS

Seepage wetlands, found along slopes and at the base of ridges, were historically undervalued by forestry due to their wet, uneven terrain and limited timber volume. In many cases, they were disturbed during harvest operations—used for skid trails or inadvertently compacted by heavy equipment.

Although not a major source of merchantable timber, these wetlands were often ditched or drained in attempts to improve forest access or expand planting areas, leading to hydrologic disruption and loss of rare, moisture-dependent plant communities.

Today, seepage wetlands are recognized for their water filtration, habitat diversity, and rare species, making them critical to sustainable forest landscapes. Modern operations follow BMPs, use low-impact techniques, and apply restorative strategies to protect and enhance these sensitive ecosystems.

HABITAT DESCRIPTION

Seepage wetlands are found throughout the state often near the base of slopes or swales within forested uplands. They are saturated for at least part of the year with water moving towards a stream or draw. Seepage areas often cross over or under boulder fields or rock outcrops or, in the coastal plain, may consist of impermeable clay with a slight peat surface layer. They can encompass a few hundred square feet or several acres.

Swap Priority Habitat

Ecoregion(s)

Gravelly Seeps

Blue Ridge and Southwestern Appalachian

Hillside Seeps

Southeastern Plains, Southern Coastal Plains

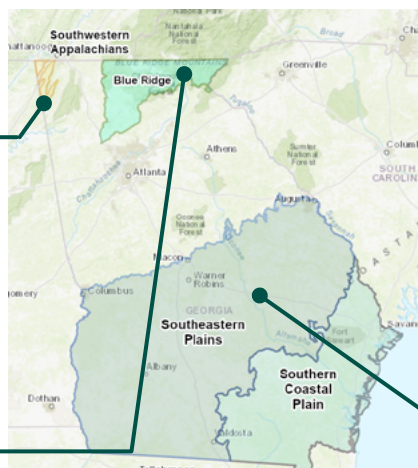
Mountain Bogs and Wet Meadows

Blue Ridge

Low Elevation Seepy Thickets and Wet Woods

**MOUNTAIN BOG BY
ALAN CRESSLER**

**MOUNTAIN SEEPAGE RAVINE BY
ALAN CRESSLER**



**HILLSIDE SEEP, POWERLINE BY
ERIN CORK, GA DNR**

THREATS

- Fire suppression can degrade these habitats by allowing competition from undesirable competing vegetation.
- Alterations to hydrology such as ditching, draining, filling in wetlands, and water impoundments
- Invasion of exotic pest plants and animals
- Firebreaks, roads, and ruts caused by heavy vehicle traffic interrupt the natural progression of fire, change hydrology, and reduce movement of wildlife.
- Indiscriminate herbicide use or mechanical vegetation treatments can reduce plant biodiversity and negatively impact ecosystem function.
- Pollution and upstream sedimentation alter hydrology and water quality.

CONSERVATION MANAGEMENT RECOMMENDATIONS

- Avoid bedding, mechanical site preparation, and other soil disturbances.
- Retire fire breaks and allow fires to burn through these areas when possible.
- Protect from pollution and erosion runoff from nearby operations.
- Use selective spot herbicide and mechanical treatments to control exotic pest plants.
- Reduce invasion by woody vegetation utilizing prescribed fire on a 2-3-year rotation or with selective spot applications of herbicide if prescribed fire management is not an option.

MORE INFORMATION

Visit Georgia Biodiversity Portal for more information about specific species and habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIABIODIVERSITY.ORG](https://georgiabiodiversity.org)

Georgia's State Wildlife Action Plan has more information about specific management actions to protect these habitats:

[HTTPS://GEORGIAWILDLIFE.COM/WILDLIFEACTIONPLAN](https://georgiawildlife.com/wildlifeactionplan)

SELECTED PRIORITY SPECIES



See full list of Species
via QR code below

Georgia's Forestry BMP manual is designed to help landowners prevent or minimize impacts to water systems, the manual is available online.

[HTTPS://GATREES.ORG](https://gatrees.org)

View the GA SIC Storyboard
for more information and resources

